becomes more prominent and important as a result of China's rise.

It is argued that we are now returning to a new bipolar world structure, with the United States and China as the two leading poles in the international system.[13] In a bipolar system, according to Kenneth Waltz, internal balancing is more important than external balancing (forming alliances), because other major powers do not have the capabilities to change the balance of power in any significant way.[14] Nevertheless, some form of strategic alignment with another second-ranked great power could still be useful in a bipolar system, with the United States playing the "China card" against the Soviet Union in the 1970s and 1980s as the obvious historical precedent. Notwithstanding that neither India nor Japan is able to change the power equilibrium in Asia vis-à-vis China in any significant way, both countries would still play an important role in enabling the United States to maintain its forward presence in the region. Furthermore, in similar terms as playing the China card against the Soviet Union during the Cold War forced Moscow to balance two flanks simultaneously, it would currently be of interest to the United States to draw India closer into its orbit, forcing China to balance two flanks. Moreover, as the strategic theatre is about to expand from the Western Pacific to the larger Indo-Pacific region, India's role becomes more prominent. Various administrations in Washington have since the mid-2000s worked to improve relations between the United States and India. Positioning itself vis-à-vis China and the United States without reducing its strategic autonomy will be a delicate balancing act for New Delhi over the coming years.

In this volume, we engage with how these five developments – India's emergence as the dominant power in South Asia, its more pro-active foreign policy towards its own neighbourhood as well as the great powers, the growing importance of the Indian Ocean Region, India's widening